

⚡ ESSENTIAL SURVIVAL QUICK-REFERENCE

Sourced from: FM 3-05.70 · TC 4-02.1 · FEMA · CDC · NOAA · USGS · NRC | Public Domain

THE RULE OF THREES

3 min without air · 3 hrs without shelter (extreme cold) · 3 days without water · 3 weeks without food

💧 BLEEDING & TRAUMA

MARCH Protocol:

- M – Massive hemorrhage:** Tourniquet 2–3" above wound, tighten until bleeding stops, note time
 - A – Airway:** Tilt head, lift chin. Unconscious → recovery position
 - R – Respiration:** Seal chest wounds with palm, tape 3 sides
 - C – Circulation:** Direct pressure on wounds, do NOT remove dressings
 - H – Hypothermia:** Keep victim warm, off ground
- Tourniquet:** Never remove in field. Write application time on forehead or tourniquet.

💧 WATER

Priority order:

- Running water over still; upstream from activity
- Boil:** Rolling boil 1 min (3 min at altitude >6,500 ft)
- Bleach:** 8 drops unscented per gallon, wait 30 min
- Iodine:** 5 drops per liter, wait 30 min (clear water)
- Dehydration signs:** dark urine, headache, confusion
- Daily min:** 1 qt/day survival, 2 qt/day activity
- Never drink:** seawater, urine, blood, alcohol, raw floodwater without treatment

🔥 FIRE

- Fire Triangle:** Heat + Fuel + Oxygen
- Build order:** Tinder → Kindling → Fuel (smallest to largest)
- Methods (no lighter):**
- **Bow drill:** dry softwood spindle on dry fireboard
 - **Flint & steel:** strike at 30° toward tinder
 - **Lens:** focus sunlight on dark tinder (sunny day)
- Distress signal:** 3 fires in triangle = international distress
- In rain:** build under canopy; use birch bark, pine resin, dry inner bark

🏠 SHELTER

Priority: Ground insulation > wind block > rain cover

Lean-to (fastest):

- Ridge pole 7 ft between two trees
 - Lean branches at 45° angle
 - Layer debris shingle-style, top to bottom
 - 4" debris on ground for insulation
- Heat loss:** 60% from head/neck — always cover
- Ideal interior temp:** above 60°F
- Avoid:** valley bottoms (cold air, flooding), lone tall trees (lightning), dry riverbeds (flash flood)

🧭 NAVIGATION

- Map:** Align map north with compass; adjust for magnetic declination
- Pace count:** Count LEFT foot strikes. ~100 paces = 100 m (varies by terrain)
- Sun navigation:**
- Sunrise = East / Sunset = West
 - **Stick shadow:** mark tip, wait 15 min, mark again → line = E–W
 - **Polaris:** end of Little Dipper's handle
- Terrain:** Ridge (elongated high), Draw (valley between ridges), Saddle (dip between peaks)
- Lost? STOP:** Stop · Think · Observe · Plan

⚡ WEATHER THREATS

- Tornado:**
- WARNING = take cover NOW. Lowest floor, interior room, away from windows. Abandon mobile homes. Cover head/neck.
- Lightning (30/30 rule):**
- Thunder within 30 sec of flash → seek shelter. Wait 30 min after last thunder. Avoid trees, hilltops, open fields, water, metal.
- Flash Flood:**
- Never** walk/drive through moving water. 6" knocks you down; 2 ft floats most vehicles. Move to high ground.
- Extreme Heat:**
- Drink every 15–20 min. **Heat stroke:** hot DRY skin, confusion, no sweating → call 911, cool with ice/water immediately.

☢️ NUCLEAR / RADIATION

Get Inside · Stay Inside · Stay Tuned:

- Within 10–15 min: find nearest solid building
 - Go to center of middle floor or basement
 - Stay 24 hrs minimum (radiation drops 80% in 24h)
 - Remove outer clothing outside; shower ASAP
 - Seal windows/doors with tape/plastic if possible
 - Monitor EAS (Emergency Alert System) radio
- KI (Potassium Iodide):** Only protects thyroid from radioactive iodine. Take only if directed by authorities.
- Contamination sign:** dirt/debris on skin/clothes from blast = potential fallout

🍄 FOOD & FORAGING

Edibility test (one part at a time):

- Smell: sour/bitter = suspect
 - Skin contact: rub on wrist, wait 15 min
 - Lip contact: wait 3 min, check for burning
 - Tongue tip: wait 15 min
 - Chew small amount, spit, wait 8 hrs
 - Eat small amount, wait 8 hrs
- Safe:** Dandelion (all parts), cattail, pine needles (Vit C tea), acorns (leach tannins), clover
- Avoid:** Shiny berries, umbrella flowers, milky sap, beans/seeds in pods, fine hairs, bitter/soapy/almond taste
- Hunting priority:** Insects > fish > small mammals

📶 SIGNALING & RESCUE

- Universal distress:** 3 of anything — 3 shots, 3 whistle blasts, 3 fires
- Ground-to-air signals:**
- **V** = Need assistance
 - **X** = Need medical help
 - → = Traveling this direction
 - † = All OK
- Mirror signal:** Aim reflected light at aircraft; flash S-O-S (3 short · 3 long · 3 short)
- Visibility:** Orange, yellow, red visible from aircraft
- Stay near crash site** or last known position — searchers look there first.
- Cell phone:** Even no service = can call 911. Text often works when voice fails.